

DESIGN SUPPORT DOCUMENT: CODECAMPUS

GROUP: LATE TO THE PARTY

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IMY 320 GROUP DESIGN B

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1. Introduction

This document explains how CodeCampus's redesigned course catalogue and course detail page are supported by the group's UX research, how the design applies Fitts's Law, and how it satisfies the client's stated need. The client's brief for Group Design B was explicit: replace a cell/card-based catalogue with a traditional, sortable, searchable list, and give users a way to access a course's full description from that list.

To ground this redesign in evidence rather than assumption, each group member independently evaluated an existing e-learning platform's course catalogue and course detail flow using a shortened User Experience Questionnaire (UEQ-S), then rated it against Fitts's Law considerations of target size, spacing and position (Schrepp, Hinderks and Thomaschewski, 2017). The three platforms evaluated were Khan Academy, Udemy and Coursera. This document synthesises those three reports into a single set of design guidelines and shows how CodeCampus's catalogue and course detail page put them into practice.

2. Persona

Thabo M., the Career-Switching Builder

"I don't have time to scroll through fifty course cards. Just show me a list I can sort and search."

Key goal (stated as an outcome):

Find and start the coding course that matches his current skill level and available time, without spending long stretches of time browsing.

Behaviour:

- Browses in short bursts between work and family commitments, rarely more than 10 to 15 minutes at a time.
- Scans many options quickly rather than reading every course description in full.
- Relies on search, sort and filter tools rather than endless scrolling through a grid.

Must:

- Let him sort, search and filter the full catalogue quickly.
- Show enough information in the list itself (language, level, duration, one-line description) that most decisions can be made without opening every course.
- Give one-click access to a course's full description and a clear way to start it.

Mustn't:

- Bury the sort and search tools below the fold or require extra clicks to reveal them.
- Force him to open multiple tabs or cards just to compare a handful of options.

- Waste his limited browsing time with a layout whose clickable areas are small or inconsistent.

3. Task Model

Goal:

Find and start the right coding course quickly.

Order of tasks:

- Open the course catalogue.
- Scan the list of available courses.
- Sort or search to narrow by language, level or duration.
- Compare a small shortlist of rows.
- Open a course's detail page to read the full description.
- Decide whether to enrol.

Evaluation type:

Mostly a Controlled Evaluation, comparing a manageable set of concrete attributes (language, level, duration) across shortlisted rows, with a Direct Connection component when Thabo already knows what he wants and types it straight into search (for example "Python").

Content requirements:

Course title, language or technology, level, duration, and a short one-line description need to be visible directly in the list row, so most decisions can be made without opening the detail page for every option.

4. User Journey

Phase	What Thabo does	Emotion
1. Discover	Lands on the catalogue after logging in, with about 15 minutes before his next commitment.	Slightly impatient
2. Scan	Scrolls the list; titles, levels and durations are visible without opening each course.	Relieved
3. Compare	Uses the sort of control to bring "Beginner" Python courses to the top of the list.	In control
4. Decide	Opens a course, reads the short description, and clicks "Start Course."	Confident

5. Synthesis of UX Research

All three reference platforms (Khan Academy, Udemy, Coursera) use a card or tile-based catalogue, the exact pattern the client wants to move away from. A data limitation should be noted here: Khan Academy's report used the full 8-criteria UEQ-S, while the Udemy and Coursera reports used a 5-criteria subset (Boring-Exciting, Conventional-Innovative, Usual-Modern, Inefficient-Efficient, Not Interesting-Interesting). The table below compares the five criteria all three reports have in common.

Criterion	Khan Academy	Udemy	Coursera	Cross-site average
Boring-Exciting	4.3	3.7	5.3	4.43
Conventional-Innovative	3.3	5	5.3	4.53
Usual-Modern	4.3	5.3	5	4.87
Inefficient-Efficient	5.7	4.7	4.7	5.03
Not Interesting-Interesting	4	4.7	5.7	4.8

The most important pattern is in the Efficient row. All three sites use a grid/card catalogue, yet Khan Academy (5.7) scored noticeably higher than Udemy (4.7) and Coursera (4.7), both of which sit barely above the neutral midpoint. The difference is not the presence of a grid itself; it is what each card is asking a user to aim at. Khan Academy's tiles are simple, largely a single subject icon and label. Udemy and Coursera's cards pack a thumbnail, title, rating, provider name and badges into one card, splitting the clickable area into several smaller, competing targets. This is consistent with what the Udemy and Coursera reports independently concluded: smaller, more fragmented targets inside a card reduce perceived efficiency, exactly what Fitts's Law predicts.

Innovative and Modern show the opposite trend: Khan Academy's plain layout scored lowest (3.3 and 4.3), while Udemy and Coursera's more visually styled cards scored higher (5.0 to 5.3). Read together, the three reports show a consistent trade-off between visual novelty and target efficiency, and support the client's instinct that a plain, functional list is not a step backwards in perceived quality, it trades a small amount of novelty for a meaningful gain in how quickly and accurately users can act.

The Coursera report also flagged that Innovative and Modern had the widest spread between participants of any criteria measured (Innovative ranged 3 to 7, Modern ranged 4 to 7), meaning a grid's visual appeal is inconsistent from person to person, whereas Efficient scores were comparatively more stable across participants on all three sites. A design goal that depends on being universally perceived as efficient is a safer target than one that depends on being universally perceived as exciting or innovative.

6. Design Guidelines Derived

Combining the guidelines independently proposed across all three reports into a single set for the CodeCampus catalogue and course detail page:

- Give each catalogue row a single, large click target covering the whole row (icon, title, level, duration and description snippet together), rather than isolating the clickable area to the title or a small icon.
- Keep the sort and search controls fixed and prominent at the top of the list, ideally remaining visible while scrolling, so they don't need to be relocated.
- Use clear, consistent vertical spacing between list rows so adjacent targets don't compete for the same pointing motion.
- Where a small interactive icon is genuinely needed inside a row (for example a bookmark or wishlist icon), give it generous padding and separation from the row's main click target.
- Preserve visual richness, a language icon, level badge, or short thumbnail, within the list format, so the efficiency gained from a list does not come at the cost of all visual appeal.
- On the course detail page, place the primary action ("Start Course") as a large, high-contrast target near the top of the page, since that is the single most Fitts's-Law-critical interaction once a course has been selected.
- Do not over-invest in making the catalogue feel visually inventive for its own sake. Across all three reference sites, high Innovative or Modern scores did not track with highly Efficient scores, and the client explicitly asked for function over novelty.

7. Fitts's Law Application

Fitts's Law states that the time required to move to and select a target is a function of the distance to that target and its size: larger, closer targets are acquired faster and with fewer errors (Wong, 2026). This principle is the core design constraint for Group Design B, and it maps directly onto the client's complaint about "cells": a grid of small cards packs multiple sub-targets (thumbnail, title, badge) into a compact area, increasing both the number of targets a user must aim between and the precision required to hit the right one.

CodeCampus's list-based catalogue addresses this in three concrete ways. First, target size: each row spans the full width of the list and uses generous vertical padding, so the clickable area is large regardless of where in the row a user clicks. Second, target spacing: consistent gaps between rows reduce the chance of a user selecting the wrong course by mistake, directly reflecting Fitts's Law's spacing consideration. Third, target position: the search bar and sort control sit in a fixed location at the top of the list, so returning users do not need to relocate them, reducing the distance component of the Fitts's Law equation over repeated visits.

8. Design Walkthrough

8.1 Course Catalogue Page

The catalogue replaces the card grid pattern seen on all three reference sites with a vertical list. Each row is a single clickable element containing a small language/technology icon, the course title, a level badge (Beginner, Intermediate, Advanced), an estimated duration, and a one-line description, all inside one generously

padding target rather than several small ones. A search field and a sort of control (by language, level, or duration) sit in a fixed bar at the top of the list, always visible while scrolling, so Thabo never has to scroll back up to change his sort or search term.

8.2 Course Detail Page

Opening a row takes the user to a course detail page with the course title and a short summary at the top, followed immediately by a large, high contrast “Start Course” button rather than requiring the user to scroll past a long description first. A clearly labelled link back to the catalogue is placed near the top of the page so users can return to their sorted/searched list without losing their place.

9. How the Design Satisfies the Client's Need

The client's problem statement asked for three specific things: a traditional list instead of cells, the ability to sort and search, and access to each course's description from the list. The catalogue redesign satisfies all three directly: the layout is a vertical list of rows, not a grid of cards; a fixed sort and search bar sits at the top of that list; and each row's one-line description, plus one click through to the full course detail page, gives access to more information without ever needing to leave the list to compare options.

10. Conclusion

The three UX evaluations conducted for this deliverable all point to the same conclusion: card-based catalogues can look modern, but the more sub-targets they pack into a single card, the less efficient they are perceived to be, a direct, measurable illustration of Fitts's Law. CodeCampus's list-based catalogue and course detail page apply that finding directly, using large, consistently spaced, predictably positioned targets to satisfy both the client's explicit request and the usability principle behind it.

11. References

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